

The Economic and Social Consequences of Inadequate Access to Clean Drinking Water in Teota

The people of Teota in Manikganj continue to suffer from multidimensional vulnerabilities driven by environmental instability. Among all these, the lack of access to clean drinking water became an extreme issue influencing not only health outcomes but also other economic and social conditions.

Concurrently, frequent river erosion has caused constant displacement, disrupting the trend of access to facilities such as tube wells. In most cases, tube wells do not exist or are contaminated by arsenic and iron. With the scarcity of deep tube wells, the crisis is further exacerbated so that households end up depending on unreliable natural sources that often dry up during dry seasons.

Economic implications of water scarcity are pivotal. Conventional livestock-based households (who rely on raising livestock for income) - particularly during Eid-ul-Adha - also incur higher costs as cattle, as well as human health deteriorates due to poor quality water. Healthcare spending, though limited due to the low levels of medical facilities, is an additional cost incurred by households, who are already operating on the margin. Moreover, labor and time are diverted away from productive activities into searching for water, sometimes carried out over long distances in an effort to find cleaner sources.

The inability to access clean water also leads to long-term social issues. For instance: it has been observed that there have been frequent cases of child marriage, partly as a strategy for economic coping. Families with shrinking resources and rising insecurity may view early marriage as one way to reduce family size and financial dependence. Unfortunately, this trend often results in lower educational opportunities for girls, perpetuating cycles of poverty and low-skilled jobs.

Furthermore, the lack of electricity and medical services worsens the vulnerability generated by water shortage. Without basic public services, private solutions remain inaccessible to most residents, whereas limited interventions made by NGOs fall short of addressing structural requirements. Although some NGOs provide cattle and training, such efforts are incapable of addressing basic problems related to water access.

Lacking a concerted, long-term social intervention with investments in deep tube wells, improved sanitation facilities, and targeted public services, the community's ability to achieve economic resilience remains severely constrained. Subsequently, it can be assessed that clean drinking water is not only a health necessity but a fundamental precondition for educational, economic, and social stability.

A sustainable approach would entail safe water infrastructure as an essential component of long-term rural development policy. Without such, the Teota communities will be progressively trapped in cycles of displacement, health risk, and economic stagnation.

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